

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1992-04-21

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

1 Ridván 1992

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

2 dearly loved f riends,

3 At this rixván season, with its inherent splendors and its initiation of
4 unusual, eventful days, our hearts throb in wonderment, we kneel in hom-
5 age to the king of glory by whose grace we have arrived at an auspicious
6 juncture in the history of h is cause.

from the peak of triumph of the Six year plan now ended, we come to

7 the threshold of the holy year, now begun, awestruck at the very thought of
8 the unique significances associated with the commemoration of that sancti-fied
occasion one hundred years ago when bahá'u'lláh, the promised one
9 of all ages, took his leave of this earthly life. The Sun of T ruth, however,
10 was to set only to shine everlastingly from the “kingdom of fadeless glory,”
thenceforward to shed the radiance of its regenerative power on the entire
11 world. gone from this plane was he who is the Author of a revelation of
12 “inconceivable greatness” in which “all the dispensations of the past have
13 attained their highest, their final consummation”; the originator of a new
14 universal cycle “that must extend over a period of at least five hundred

thousand years”; the founder of a world order, a “System—the like of

which mortal eyes have never witnessed.” moreover, he was the dawning

15 point of the day of god, the “d ay in which god’s most excellent favors

have been poured out upon men.”

16 129-1 Such are the superlative realities upon

17 which our contemplations are focused during this special anniversary occur-ring at
this crucial moment in the affairs of humankind.

18 So imbued are we by the sacred remembrances evoked by this holy year,
 19 that we can do no less than invite you all to take pause to enter into this
 20 period of reflection, this time of reconsecration, this stage of preparation for
 21 tasks yet to be done, heights yet to be attained, splendors yet to be unveiled.
 22 for if we look back at one hundred years of an unexampled history of un-
 23 remitting progress, we also look forward to many centuries of unfolding fulfillment
 of divine purpose—fulfillment, which as experience has shown,
 24 129-1. Sw Ab, no. 5.1; Sh, ¶152; wob, p. 102; kA, ¶181.129.1
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 131 265 is incrementally realized through the systematic advances of plans and the
 132 wondrous leaps and thrusts of epochs.
 133 indeed, the immediate portal to this propitious holy year is the vista of
 134 new horizons opened by the triumph of the Six year p lan, which coincided
 135 with the initial phase of the fourth epoch of the formative Age of our faith.
 136 overall it is not so much a triumph in numerical achievements, though in
 137 many places and at particular moments the scope of expansion was extraor-
 138 dinary. it is a triumph that has been manifested in a new variety of victories,
 139 in new beginnings, fresh initiatives and mature institutional developments, such as to
 stamp the seal of success on the plan's seven major objectives.
 140 impossible as it is to enumerate in these few pages the results of the plan,
 141 the main aspects of the developments in this remarkably dynamic period deserve,
 nonetheless, to be highlighted. The bahá'í community changed
 142 markedly over the last six years. The major indicators are, no doubt, discern-ible to
 the friends everywhere and may be summed up thus:
 143 one: The faith of bahá'u'lláh is represented in every country on earth.
 144 The sudden change in the political climate, no doubt by intervention of
 145 god's major plan, opened vast regions to the penetration of the divine
 146 teachings, primarily in the former Soviet union and eastern bloc coun-
 147 tries. The opportunities created by this change made possible the settle-
 148 ment of knights of bahá'u'lláh in the last virgin territories that remained

from Shoghi effendi's Ten year world crusade. They also impelled the

149 launching at riḡvān 1990 of the subsidiary T wo year plan for those regions.

150 This supplementary plan was a spectacular success, not only in terms of

151 expansion in the many countries involved, but also in the diversity of the strata
represented by the new believers in these countries, in the volume and variety of bahá'í
literature published and in the array of bahá'í institutions

152 established during that short time. The bahá'í world was highly stimulated

153 by these developments, and a number of countries elsewhere recorded significant
successes in the teaching work. figures already available to the

154 world center indicate that more than one and a half million souls entered

155 the cause during the Six year plan. of particular interest was the three-year

156 special teaching project in guyana which resulted in an increase of the size

157 of the b ahá'í community to some six percent of the country's population.

T wo: The proclamation of the faith throughout the world attained

158 an entirely new stage. The campaign of proclamation launched in 1967 through the
inspiration of the centennial anniversary of bahá'u'lláh's proc-

159 lamation to the kings and rulers of mankind, and which gathered added 129.4

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130 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

131 266momentum in 1979 with the surge of the persecution of the iranian bahá'í

community, now covered a greatly expanded range with the distribution

132 of The Promise of World Peace. kings, queens, presidents, prime ministers,

133 legislators, jurists, academics, diverse institutions and organizations became

134 aware of bahá'u'lláh's message. The creative energies by which communities

everywhere were exercised in broadcasting the cause became one of the

135 driving forces of the plan and in no small way stimulated the interest of

136 organizations, leaders of thought and the media in the solutions which the faith has
to offer to a strangely disordered world. inspired by the impact of

137 the measures they adopted for proclamation of the faith, and also by that of

138 their continuing efforts to defend the sorely persecuted iranian bahá'í com-

139 munity, National and local Spiritual Assemblies displayed and continue to

140 display a striking audacity and originality in dealing with the public. This
141 is evident in their innumerable contacts with officials at all levels of govern-
142 ment, in their association with a widening spectrum of organizations, and in the
increasing facility of their contacts with the media.

Three: The dedication in december 1986 of the mother Temple of the

143 indian Subcontinent to public worship introduced a new force to the teach-
144 ing and proclamation activities of the faith. As an edifice of rare beauty
145 and excellence, the “lotus Temple” has won wide acclaim, while at the same time
exerting an extraordinary appeal to great numbers of visitors. its fame
146 as an architectural wonder spread with speed as did its spiritual influence. it is no
exaggeration to say that of all the bahá’í houses of worship, this
147 Temple is today the single most effective silent teacher of the faith, annu-
148 ally attracting more visitors, at the average rate of 20,000 daily, than all the other
bahá’í Temples combined. Among its visitors from many lands
149 are some of the most prominent persons in the world. A source of great interest to the
media, the Temple has been featured in television programs,
150 even in russia and china. The influence of its success in these respects has
151 contributed immeasurably to the widespread public awareness of the f aith.
152 four: The further emergence of the faith from obscurity is reflected in
153 distinctive ways. in learned circles, in reference works and in the media,
154 the faith is increasingly being referred to as a “principal” or “major” world
155 religion. media coverage of the faith’s activities has increased voluminously
156 by the intensified efforts of the friends in proclamation activities, but more important
is the fact that the media are showing an independent interest in
157 the bahá’í community and are initiating contacts with it in various parts of
158 the world. The exposure of influential segments of the public to bahá’í ideas 129.7

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131 267in such areas as peace, the environment, status of women, education and
132 literacy, has induced a response which increasingly calls upon the bahá’ís to
133 participate with others in a range of projects associated with governments or with
nongovernmental organizations.

134 moreover, such exposure is creating in the public mind the realization

135 that the faith has answers to current problems and thus the expectation that
136 the bahá'í community should take a more active part in public affairs. The
137 notable success of the activities of the bahá'í international community's
138 office of the environment, established during the plan, amply illustrates the
139 nature of these developments. furthermore, the formal relationship which
140 the bahá'í international community established with the conservation and

religion Network of the world wide fund for Nature and with the world

141 conference on religion and peace, in conjunction with the numerous such
142 relationships established by National and local Spiritual Assemblies in their
143 respective jurisdictions, reflects a trend in the faith's emergence as an entity
144 to be reckoned with. Altogether, the drive of the ramified proclamation campaign has
produced a public resonance about the faith, which can be
145 said to be known to the most significant public institutions and prominent persons on
earth.

five: bahá'í projects of social and economic development have greatly

146 multiplied and brought much credit to the community in the examples of
147 the power of group initiative and voluntary consultative action that have
148 been set in numerous places. Activities in this respect involved more than one
thousand projects in the areas of education, agriculture, health, literacy,
149 the environment and improvement of the status of women. in a number of
150 instances the projects benefited from collaboration with or assistance from
151 governments and international nongovernmental organizations, as, for ex-ample, the
projects for the improvement of the status of women undertaken
152 by five National Spiritual Assemblies with the financial assistance of the

united Nations development fund for women (uNifem), and those

153 projects in other fields receiving assistance from the canadian, indian, ger-
154 man and Norwegian governments. Some projects have been so distinguished
155 in their achievements as to be given public notice through the citations and
156 awards of governments and international nongovernmental agencies.
157 Six: youth activities took on a special character shaped by the idea of a
158 youth year of service. The involvement of the youth in the Six year plan

159 as short-term pioneers, traveling teachers and projectors had a profound effect on
the teaching work overall and in bolstering the efforts at social 129.9

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130 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

131 268 and economic development attempted by growing numbers of national and

local communities. They had much to do with the many victories in the

132 former communist countries. Their work in social and economic develop-

133 ment projects attracted, in some cases, the attention of governments and development
organizations. creation of the european bahá'í youth council

134 galvanized the activities of the youth which powerfully reinforced the teach-

135 ing thrust on that continent during the final years of the plan. A significant

136 feature of the youth's activities has been their involvement, as short-term

137 volunteers from all parts of the planet, in the work of the world center

138 where their services have been of inestimable value.

Seven: The advances in the consolidation of the bahá'í administrative

139 system are evident from the marked improvement in the internal develop-ment and
collaborative efforts of its two arms. The cherished and intrepid

140 hands of the cause of god, true to the allegiance they bear to their beloved

141 guardian, persevere in their unique services, astonishing the community

142 with their resilient powers. The growth in confidence and strength of the

143 boards of counselors and their auxiliaries, backed by a reinforced and vig-

144 orous international Teaching center, assured to the Spiritual Assemblies,

145 whom they are charged to stimulate and advise, a buttressing indispensable to the
welfare of the entire system; while the extension of the span of ac-tivities of the National and
local Spiritual Assemblies, themselves charged

146 with guiding the destinies of their communities, significantly broadened the base of
that system. collaterally, the work of these institutions has fa-

147 cilitated and boosted the evolution of the Administrative order. even more:

148 they have demonstrated a creative energy that bodes well for their continued
maturation.

149 eight: The great building projects on the mountain of god, anticipated

150 by bahá'u'lláh in the Tablet of carmel, inaugurated by 'Abdu'l-b ahá with

151 the construction of the Tomb of the báb and carried forward in the plans

of Shoghi effendi, entered a new stage. work commenced in may 1990 on

152 reinforcing and extending the main terrace of the Shrine of the báb as the
153 initial step towards realizing the architectural concept for fulfilling ‘Abdu’l-
154 bahá’s vision of the Terraces that will extend from the foot to the ridge of
155 the mountain. by September of the next year, ground was broken for the
156 construction of the center for the Study of the Texts and for the extension
157 to the international Archives building, to be followed by the construction
158 of other edifices on the Arc, namely: the buildings for the international
159 Teaching center and, in due course, the i nternational b ahá’í library.129.12

129 13

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131 269All these developments have made it evident that the accumulated po-
132 tential for further progress of the bahá’í community is incalculable. The

changed situation within and among nations and the many problems af-

133 flicting society amplify this potential. The impression produced by such change is of
the near approach of the lesser peace. but there has been a

134 simultaneous recrudescence of countervailing forces. with the fresh tide of

135 political freedom resulting from the collapse of the strongholds of commu-nism has
come an explosion of nationalism. The concomitant rise of racism in many regions has
become a matter of serious global concern. These are compounded by an upsurge in
religious fundamentalism which is poisoning

136 the wells of tolerance. Terrorism is rife. widespread uncertainty about the

137 condition of the economy indicates a deep disorder in the management of

138 the material affairs of the planet, a condition which can only exacerbate the

139 sense of frustration and futility affecting the political realm. The worsen-

140 ing state of the environment and of the health of huge populations is a source of
alarm. And yet an element of this change is the amazing advances in communications
technology making possible the rapid transmission of

141 information and ideas from one part of the world to the other. it is against

142 such “simultaneous processes of rise and fall, of integration and of disinte-

143 gration, of order and chaos, with their continuous and reciprocal reactions on each
other,” that a myriad new opportunities for the next stage in the

144 unfoldment of the beloved master's divine plan present themselves.

145 129-2

The burgeoning influence of bahá'u'lláh's revelation seemed, with the

146 imminence of the holy year, to have assumed the character of an onrushing

147 wind blowing through the archaic structures of the old order, felling mighty

148 pillars and clearing the ground for new conceptions of social organization. The call for unity, for a new world order, is audible from many directions. The change in world society is characterized by a phenomenal speed. A

149 feature of this change is a suddenness, or precipiteness, which appears

150 to be the consequence of some mysterious, rampant force. The positive aspects of this change reveal an unaccustomed openness to global concepts, movement towards international and regional collaboration, an inclination

151 of warring parties to opt for peaceful solutions, a search for spiritual values.

even the community of the most great Name itself is experiencing the

152 rigorous effects of this quickening wind as it ventilates the modes of thought

153 129-2. Adj, ¶103.129.14

129 15

130 message from The Universal House of Justice

131 270 of us all, renewing, clarifying and amplifying our perspectives as to the

132 purpose of the order of bahá'u'lláh in the wake of humanity's suffering

133 and turmoil.

134 The situation in the world, while presenting us with an acute challenge of

135 the utmost urgency, calls to mind the encouraging global vision of Shoghi Effendi for the prospects of the Administrative Order during the second

136 century of the bahá'í era, whose midpoint we are rapidly approaching. In

137 1946, he wrote: "The second century is destined to witness a tremendous deployment and a notable consolidation of the forces working towards the worldwide development of that order, as well as the first stirrings of that

138 world order, of which the present Administrative System is at once the

139 precursor, the nucleus and pattern—an order which, as it slowly crystal-

140 lizes and radiates its benign influence over the entire planet, will proclaim at

141 once the coming of age of the whole human race, as well as the maturity of

the faith itself, the progenitor of that order."

142 129-3

143 Attention to the special occasions of the holy year will surely equip us to
144 undertake the urgent tasks of the next stage in the evolution of the divine
145 plan. This commemorative period provides a befitting demarcation between
146 the glories and triumphs of the last one hundred years and the lustrous priz-es yet to
be garnered. At the outset, we welcome with joyous and grateful hearts the further
expansion and consolidation of the Administrative order
147 which will accrue from the formation this riḡván of twelve National and
148 regional Spiritual Assemblies. how striking it is that the number of these
149 Assemblies is the same as the total number of National Spiritual Assemblies which
existed at the launching of the Ten year world crusade in 1953! This
150 is gratifying evidence of the rapidity of the expansion of the Administrative order in
less than forty years. with these new Assemblies, and making
151 allowance for the absorption of Sikkim into india and the disruption of the
152 bahá'í Administration by the unsettled situation in liberia, the number of
153 National Spiritual Assemblies which will take part in the seventh interna-
154 tional b ahá'í convention next riḡván will reach 165.

we are pleased to announce that the following hands of the cause of

155 god will attend, as our representatives, six of the founding conventions.

Amatu'l-b ahá rúŷíyyih khánum will attend the conventions of bulgaria

and of poland; mr. 'Alí Akbar furútan will attend those of the baltic

156 129-3. Tdh, no. 158.14.129.16

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131 271States and of hungary; and dr. 'Alí-m uŷammad varqá will attend those
132 of greenland and of the ukraine, belarus, and moldova. At the remaining
133 conventions our representatives will be counselors: mr. george Allen, the
134 congo republic; dr. farzam Arbab, central Asia; mr. rolf von czékus,
135 Angola; mrs. parvin djoneidi, Niger; mr. hartmut grossmann, Albania;
136 and mr. m as'úd khamsí, Azerbaijan.

only a few weeks from now, in the sacred precincts of the Shrine of

137 bahá'u'lláh, a gathering of solemn purpose will take place to mark the one
138 hundredth anniversary of the Ascension of the desire of the Nations. The
139 scroll bearing the roll of honor of the knights of bahá'u'lláh will, on the
140 previous morning, 28 may, have been deposited, as indicated by our be-
141 loved guardian, at the entrance door of the inner Sanctuary of the most
142 holy Shrine, there to remain a symbol of the historic victory that rewarded
143 the unswerving determination of the lovers of the blessed beauty who, in
144 response to the call of the mighty Ten year crusade, planted the banner of
145 his faith in virgin territories throughout the world.

146 Subsequently, in November, at the second bahá'í world congress,
147 the hosts of bahá will gather in New york in their thousands to register,
148 in a highly symbolic gesture on behalf of their brethren throughout the
149 world, their regard for the covenant which bahá'u'lláh bequeathed, and

to evoke the memory of him who was appointed its center and who

150 exalted that metropolis by bestowing upon it the designation "city of the covenant."

151 129-4 There they will also demonstrate the power of the unity that
152 the covenant is meant to ensure to all the peoples of the world. it will be a
153 moment of capital importance to the bahá'í community in the gaze of the
154 world at large.

155 These two international events are pivotal to the gatherings of similar
156 intent in which the friends in every corner of the world will take part. The
157 spiritual character and dignified manner of their participation will surely
158 draw down confirmations from on high and profoundly influence the con-structive
forces at work throughout the earth.

Another source of blessings to which we have long directed our hopes

159 will also become manifest. bahá'u'lláh has written: " while in prison we

have revealed a book which we have entitled 'The most holy book.' we

have enacted laws therein and adorned it with the commandments of thy

160 129-4. gpb, p. 288.129.19

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m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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272lord, who exerciseth authority over all that are in the heavens and on the

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earth."129-5 hence, it is with full cognizance of its world-shaking significance

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that we inform you of the forthcoming publication during the course of this

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year of the annotated english translation of the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the charter

135

of the future world civilization which bahá'u'lláh revealed in the house of

136

'údí khammár in 'Akká some six score years ago.

137

And now, amid the eager anticipations occasioned by the two major com-

memorative events and by the imminent publication of the mother book

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of the bahá'í revelation, the law of puqúqu'lláh takes effect as part of the

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constant practice of the members of our entire world community. may the

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promised divine bounties associated with the activation of this holy law be showered upon the beloved of the lord in every land.

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A year charged with happenings of such sacred import is bound to yield

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consequences of unimaginable potency. The immediate outcome is, how-ever, impossible to predict, nor can it be fruitfully speculated about. rather

should we direct our thoughts to the meaning of the solemn occasions

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which this year is set apart to memorialize. for the purpose of the holy year

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is not fulfilled by public memorials alone, befitting as they will be. essential

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to its purpose is the opportunity it offers for inner reflection on the part of every bahá'í individual. indeed, this is a special time for a rendezvous of the

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soul with the Source of its light and guidance, a time to turn to bahá'u'lláh,

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to seek to obtain a deeper appreciation of his purpose, to renew allegiance

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to him. This is a time of retreat to one's innermost being, to the dwelling-

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place of the Spirit of bahá, that interior to which he summons us when he

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says: "T urn thy sight unto thyself, that thou mayest find me standing within

thee, mighty, powerful and self-subsisting."

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129-6 This is a time for recommit-

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ment to the covenant, for rededication to duty, for revitalizing the energy

for teaching, the "most meritorious of all deeds."129-7

153 As the foremost aid to your reflections and actions, you will doubtless
154 draw upon the insight and inspiration of such of his words as these: "i am
the Sun of wisdom and the ocean of knowledge. i cheer the faint and
155 revive the dead. i am the guiding light that illumineth the way." "b y my
156 life! Not of mine own volition have i revealed myself, but god, of his own
157 choosing, hath manifested me." "i have come in the shadows of the clouds
158 129-5. Tb, p. 261.
159 129-6. hw , Arabic, no. 13.
160 129-7 . gwb, no. 128.10.129.23
129 24
129 25
130 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Y e a r
131 27of glory, and am invested by god with invincible sovereignty." "h e that
132 hath me not is bereft of all things. T urn ye away from all that is on earth and
133 seek none else but me." "love me, that i may love thee. if thou lovest me
134 not, my love can in no wise reach thee. know this, o servant." "The An-
135 cient beauty hath consented to be bound with chains that mankind may be
136 released from its bondage, and hath accepted to be made a prisoner within
this most mighty Stronghold that the whole world may attain unto true
137 liberty. he hath drained to its dregs the cup of sorrow, that all the peoples
138 of the earth may attain unto abiding joy, and be filled with gladness."129-8
139 whatever our private reflections or response to duty may lead us to do,
140 of one thing we must be sure: that the Name of him who is the lifegiver
of the world becomes known throughout the earth among high and low
141 alike. considering that it is already a whole century since the blessed beauty
142 ascended, and given the crushing weight of the ills burdening the peoples of the
world, and seeing that a veritable cry of anguish is issuing more loudly
143 from the hearts of those who long for some hope of relief, we, his avowed
144 servants, can neither falter nor fail in this primary and urgent duty. for he,
145 bahá'u'lláh, is the Supreme manifestation, the unifier and redeemer of all
146 mankind, the fountainhead of justice, the immortal beloved; for, accord-

147 ing to his own unerring proclamation, "h e who is the unconditioned is
148 come, in the clouds of light, that he may quicken all created things with the
149 breezes of his Name, the most merciful, and unify the world, and gather

all men around this Table which hath been sent down from heaven."

150 129-9

151 let us bear his Name with dignity to those who must hear it, offer it as a
152 treasure to those who must receive it, speak it with love to those who must
153 embrace i t.

how laudable it would be if, imbued by this desire to blazon abroad

154 his Name, and as a demonstration of our special love for the Abhá beauty,

we could each of us mount a personal campaign of teaching, such that

155 the collective force and results of it throughout the world would bring to a
resounding conclusion the sacred exercises of this holy year and set the

156 stage for the launching of the impending Three y ear p lan at riṣván 1993!

157 finally, it is highly fitting at this time to recall bahá'u'lláh's expression in
158 the most holy book of his will for us with regard to the nature of our reac-
159 129-8. Tb, p. 169; eSw , p. 11; gwb, no. 47; Tb, p. 169; hw, Arabic, no. 5;
160 gwb, no. 45.

161 129-9. eSw , p. 46.129.26

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129 28

130 m eS Sa g e S f r o m Th e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

131 27tions to his passing: "b e not dismayed, o peoples of the world," he wrote,
132 "when the day-star of my beauty is set, and the heaven of my tabernacle
133 is concealed from your eyes. Arise to further my cause, and to exalt my
134 word amongst men. we are with you at all times, and shall strengthen you
135 through the power of truth. we are truly almighty. whoso hath recognized
136 me, will arise and serve me with such determination that the powers of

earth and heaven shall be unable to defeat his purpose."129-10

137 beloved friends, we shall not forget to supplicate at the holy Threshold
138 that from his retreat of deathless splendor the blessed beauty may fill the

139 souls of each and all of you with the revivifying breath of his celestial

140 power.

141 130

Release of a Compilation on Proclaiming the Faith

through Mass Media

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]